The beard, a symbol of religiousness and piety in this society, started becoming a symbol of extremism and was seen with fear and suspicion. Conversely, the moderate bearded Muslims considered themselves odd men out in their own society. Anxiety and mistrust seeped into society. Hafiz Khalid of Jamia Ashrafia, Lahore, who wore a long beard, told that he got membership of a posh club in Lahore so that he could take his children there for swimming. He said:

> I felt myself odd man out as families seemed uncomfortable in my presence.
>
> Probably they feared that I might object on their dress or activities. Many students of my madrasah narrate not dissimilar experiences as many a times they had ill-feeling that they were being looked at suspiciously or were considered different from others.

A tangible increase took place in the intolerance of religious extremists and their tendency to thrust upon themselves the responsibility to control perceived un-Islamic activities of people. The Valentine day of 2012 faced sharp and violent reaction from different religious organisations and groups. In Lahore, some activists of Tahaffuz-Namoos-e-Risalat Mahaz (The Front for Protection of Prophet's Honour) staged a demonstration against the celebration of Valentine day; college students belonging to a religious organisation threatened and thrashed the management of a restaurant in the Gulberg area, Lahore, for arranging celebrations of Valentine's day; activists of Shabab-e-Milli (Youth organisation of Jamaat-e-Islami) went out to rally against Valentine's day and so on.[7]

International isolation

Ever since 2001, Pakistan had been badly stigmatised as the epicentre of terrorism. Many countries of the world looked to it as a centre of such activities where bombings and killings were rampant. Doubtless, terrorism was rife in the country but not all areas were affected all the time. The media, however, showed an amplified account to the outer world, making them see the country and its people in an adverse light. Many Hollywood movies and books portrayed Pakistan in a bad light, linking it with nothing but terrorism. Hollywood movies such as Iron Man, Zero Dark Thirty and The Reluctant Fundamentalist were highly